

The recent discovery of a long-lost document in the Santa Barbara Mission Archives calls for a recounting of the authentic story of a long-lost Indian Woman, Juana Maria.

Juana Maria

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A burial register might seem a strange place to get a thrill. But death record no. 1183, in an aged burial register at the Old Mission Santa Barbara, is not just an ordinary tombstone write-up, beginning simply with a name, continuing with two dates and closing with a "requiescat." Behind entry 1183 is a story thrilling as an epic; a love "strong as death;" a strange incident haunting the shadowy region which separates fact from fiction.

The story is almost unbelievable. It sounds like something from between the covers of a fairy tale book. As told by the two California pioneers who played the major roles in its climax, it came in time to be looked upon by some as a good yarn -- such as only men of the sea can conjure up -- and nothing more.

The story is that of an abandoned Indian girl, Juana Maria. The only extant authentic accounts of her strange adventure are those of Captain George Nidever and Charles Dittmann (alias, "Charley Brown") whose narratives have all the fresh qualities of being those of eye-witnesses. The strange tale needs no romantic back-drops or highly dramatic embellishments. In itself it contains all the elements of tragedy, romance, nobility, courage and even a touch of the humorous.

San Nicolas Island provides the locale of the life of Juana Maria. This lonely, desolate and windswept isle lies 70 miles almost directly south of Santa Barbara, being 120 miles directly west of the California coastal city of Oceanside.

The island once had a swarming Indian population. Where these Indians came from is not known, but writers (with what proof it is difficult to say), speak of these Indians being of a superior physical make-up; the women being tall, light-complexioned and handsome. Remains and relics indicate Aztec or Toltec origin, and this would account for Juana Maria's fair features and pleasing manners. How the numerous population of this island dwindled to the meager 20 or so natives by the year 1835 is variously conjectured. The common opinion is that the savage North West Indians frequently raided the islands of the Santa Barbara Channel. The only available information on this point is given on page 255 in the History of Santa Barbara County (documentation is not given).

"In 1811 a ship owned by Boardman and Pope, of Boston, commanded by Captain Whittemore, trading on this coast, took from the port of Sitka, Russian America, about 30 Kodiak Indians, a part of

the hardy tribe inhabiting the island of Kodiak, to the islands of the Santa Barbara Channel, for the purpose of killing sea-otter, which were then very numerous. Captain Whittemore, after landing the Kodiaks on these islands, and placing in their hands fire-arms and the other necessary implements of the chase, sailed away to the lower coast of California and South America. In the absence of the ship, a dispute arose between the Kodiaks and the natives of the islands, originating in the seizure of the females by the former. The Kodiaks possessing more activity, endurance, and knowledge of war, and possessing superior weapons, slaughtered the males without mercy, old and young. On the island of San Nicholas not a male, old or young, was spared. At the end of a year, Captain Whittemore returned to the islands, took the Kodiaks on board and carried them back to Sitka."

In the year 1835 the remnant of Indians still surviving on San Nicolas Island watched the labored action of a 20 ton ship headed for the shore. Perhaps they wondered if it would make it, for the ship went under the not too complimentary name of "Peor es Nada." Depending on the degree of excellence you care to attribute to this sea-going schooner, you may translate her name: "better than nothing," "worse than nothing," or "there is nothing worse." There is no eye-witness account of the exact nature of events that followed upon the arrival of the "Peor es Nada." Nidever received an account of the events from Isaac Sparks who had chartered the vessel for this trip. But Nidever tells us that he cannot remember the exact details, though he is under the impression that Sparks told him it happened in the following manner. They were to remove the Indians from the island, and this was being done under the authorization of someone in Los Angeles. The Indians had been gathered together at the beach preparatory to embarking on the "Peor es Nada" when one of the women made signs that she was going back to her rancheria for her child who had been overlooked in the confusion. While the Indian woman was looking for her child a strong wind sprang up. The sailors, fearing for the safety of the schooner, put off from shore and ran before the wind.

This simple account of the abandoning of the unfortunate Juana Maria to a solitary life on a lonely isle has been variously amplified -- but with what basis it is difficult to determine. Mrs. Hardacre, writing in the September 1880 edition of Scribner's Monthly, depicts the storm as already reaching a violent stage before the vessel even landed. In the consequent confusion and excitement in evacuating the island, the child of Juana Maria was left behind. The mother did not discover that her child was missing until she was already aboard the "Peor es Nada." Frantically she pleaded with the captain, but to no avail. She became desperate, and jumping overboard struck out through "the kelpy waters for the shore." No one made any attempt to save her, and "in a

moment she was lost in the seething waves" as the "ship staggered through the waves." The magazine Californian, in its Oct. edition of 1893, carried an article by James Gibbons, in which the author remarks that from the reports handed down we can infer that Juana Maria returned to the shore before the schooner was at any great distance. The sailors made signs to her that they would be back "manana." "She put her head on the ground and laid on the ground and cried; and they never came back." And then Mrs. Dudley, in an article entitled, "The Tragedy of San Nicholas Island," published in the Saturday Post of June 1, 1901, represents Juana Maria as having two children. She writes that as the last boat was to push off from shore, "a woman with a young babe in her arms sprang on shore. Her little girl, a child of 8 years, had slipped from her side in the confusion -- gone possibly in search of some remembered trinket dear to her childish heart -- or perhaps overcome with terror at the unusual migration of her people." And thus has imagination added its bit to the story.

Returning to the Nidever account (the only reliable one of the lot), we find that the commander of the schooner did intend to return to the island. But the ship, which was in popular demand, was ordered immediately to Monterey to carry a load of lumber to San Francisco. Entering the Golden Gate the "Peor es Nada" capsized and washed out to sea. There was now no other vessel on the coast that was fit to attempt the trip to San Nicolas. This sealed the fate of Juana Maria, and destined her to a life that was to make that of Robinson Crusoe look like a picnic in comparison.

The Island of San Nicolas was a far cry from any romantic environ of a South Sea island, and could by no stretch of the imagination be termed a little bit of heaven that fell out of the blue one day. Though calm and serene at certain seasons, the surrounding waters were not so throughout the entire year. A good idea of the climatic conditions of the island is given by Stephen Bowers, Ph. D., who wrote in the Ventura Observer, Dec. 20, 1892.

"The writer spent 3 weeks on the island in October 1889, and several times during his stay saw the sea lashed into fury, the waves and spray rolled up 30 feet high, and dashed against the rock-ribbed shore with a noise like thunder, and seemed to cause the very atmosphere to tremble. Never before had we witnessed such a wild and fierce struggle of the waves, though for many years accustomed to the ocean. One whole day and two nights we could not leave our tent, which was securely anchored to the side of a hill, because of the high wind and drifting sand."

This desolated island, with its roaming wild dogs and extremes of weather, was "home" to Juana Maria for 18 years. And up and down the coast it was known that an Indian woman had been abandoned on the island. But nothing was done to ascertain the na-

ture of her fate. Time rolled on, and all believed she was dead.

Seventeen years later, in 1852, Captain George Nidever, having purchased a schooner of his own, made a trip to San Nicolas for seagull eggs which were in great demand at the time. Arriving in the early morning he and a companion walked up the beach and found at a short distance from the shore footprints made by a human being. They were well-defined in the mud and quite small, evidently those of a woman. Further on they found circular huts, but these showed no signs of recent use. Outside these huts, however, they found stakes containing seal blubber which Nidever conjectured to be about 4 months old. They had seen enough to convince them of the existence of some human being and intended to make a further search -- but the invariable gale arose and they were hard pressed to get the ship back to Santa Barbara. When Fr. Gonzalez Rubio of the Old Mission heard of the discovery he requested Nidever to make a thorough search for the long lost woman.

In the winter of the same year Nidever fitted out for another trip to San Nicolas. This time he took along Carl Dittmann. As Dittmann and Nidever were walking up the island, they found in the crotch of one of the bushes a basket woven of grass. It contained a gown made of the skin of the shag (cormorant), bone needles, a sinew rope and some fishhooks made of abalone shells. After examining the things they were on the point of replacing them when it occurred to Nidever to scatter them about. If they found them replaced when they made their next visit, they would know for certain that the woman still lived. But a strong wind caused the swells to run so heavy that they had to sail to San Miguel Island.

In 1853 Nidever again made the trip to the island. This time he had in his crew, besides Dittmann, an Irishman called "Colorado," and four Mission Indians. Dittmann remarks in his manuscript that Nidever was not very sanguine about finding the woman, as he had come to the conclusion that the wild dogs had devoured her. After landing on the island, Nidever and Dittmann walked a good 6 miles up the beach to the head of the island where they again discovered footprints. But the approach of evening forced them to return to the ship. In the simple account each of the pioneers gives of the events of this first day, there is nothing of the romantic quality of Mrs. Hardacre's narrative: the two sailors strolling down the beach enjoying their pipes; the limpid California night; the moon burning with an amber hue; the fragrance in the air. "As the comrades were about to retrace their steps, Nidever stopped, looked quickly about him, then stooped and closely examined something on the ground. In the weird moonlight, plainly outlined on the lonely shore, was the print of a slender, naked foot. 'The woman of San Nicolas! My God, she is living.'" -- Well, at least it sounds good.

Immediately after breakfast the following morning, the entire crew, with the exception of the cook, began what was to be a memorable day. "Colorado" and the three Indians struck out over the sandy stretch where on the previous trip the grass basket with its gown and bone needles had been found. This they found with its contents carefully replaced. In the meantime Dittmann and Nidever went off in another direction. When Nidever grew tired and sat down to rest, Charley Brown (Dittmann) continued his search around the head of the island and up to the top of the ridge. From this vantage point Dittmann espied something far up ahead which he thought to be a crow -- and whatever it was it definitely moved. Approaching cautiously he discovered it to be the Indian woman.

She was facing in the opposite direction and hence did not notice him, though she apparently looked up every now and then and shaded her eyes to watch the men searching down on the sandy stretch. Her dress was a garment made of skins of the shag with the feathers pointing downwards. This sleeveless gown reached to her ankles, and was girded about the middle with a rope of sinew.

Dittmann attracted the attention of the other men by holding aloft his hat on the end of a ramrod and waving it up and down. The men approached from the front, and the Indian woman watched them without being in the least disturbed or excited. While the men circled about in order to prevent her escape, Dittmann stepped from the screening bushes and confronted her. He expected her to register alarm; to his surprise she bowed and smiled and seemed delighted to see him, apparently no more affected than if his visit were an everyday occurrence. She kept up a rapid conversation with herself, nobody understanding a word. As each of the men approached she bowed, smiled and spoke to them.

The searchers then signaled Nidever who came to the ridge and received the same cordial welcome. Immediately she set about to prove herself quite a hostess by roasting some roots which she passed around to the men, indicating that they should eat.

Nidever gives a description of her as she appeared when discovered. She was heavy-set and of medium height, appearing to be about fifty years old. Her features were pleasing and were made more so by the fact that she was continually smiling. Though she was missing no teeth they were badly worn, due probably to her constant diet of seal blubber. Her hair was a dull brown color and was thickly matted.

Since the Fathers at the Santa Barbara Mission had requested her return, Nidever attempted to convey to her the idea of departure; but she did not seem to understand what he meant. Dittmann, being a little better at pantomime, went through the motions of packing her things, placing them on his back and heading for the

beach. At the same time he said "vamos." This she apparently understood, for Dittman writes: "upon hearing it her face brightened up and she set to work with alacrity to get ready." The men had their hands full because she took practically everything she had. When they reached the beach she climbed into the small row-boat without any hesitation, and then crawled forward on hands and knees to the bow where she knelt holding on to both sides. That afternoon Dittmann set to work on a petticoat for the rescued woman. The sum total of his labor ended in an ensemble which consisted of a skirt, a man's shirt, a black necktie and an old coat. This was her apparel during the following month she remained with the men on the island.

That the rescued woman had seen hard times was evidenced from the fact that she saved every bone and scrap. From this private store gradually accumulated she would from time to time extricate the bones, sucking them over and over. Though her 18 years of solitude had been trying she still retained a heart that was young and gay, and could find amusement in the smallest things. A baby otter the men killed and stuffed afforded her great amusement.

After a month of hunting the rescuers and rescued headed back for Santa Barbara. A short distance from the island the vessel ran into one of those invariable storms. When the wind began to blow strongly the woman gave evidence of her belief in a supernatural power. She made signs to the men that she would quiet the wind and waves. She knelt for sometime, apparently engaged in prayer. When the wind finally abated she looked at the men and smiled, as if to say that her prayers had really brought about the quieting of the storm.

The ship finally put into Santa Barbara and the news of her rescue spread rapidly. Half the town, including Fathers Sanchez, Gonzalez and Jimeno, was at Nidever's house that night. During the following weeks the Fathers at the Mission endeavored to find Indians from different parts of the county who might understand her; but to no avail.

In spite of this handicap of language she was always gay and happy, taking special delight in playing with the Nidever children. Naturally many curious visitors came to see her, and for these she would dance and occasionally don her bird-skin dress. In a short time she became so proficient in sign language that the Nidevers were able to understand many things she wanted to say. She made known the fact that on that day 18 years before she had not found her child, and wandered about the island for many days without so much as a bit of food.

Some who have written of the heroine of San Nicolas claimed that her gentility indicated she was not the original Indian aban-

doned on the island, but was a marooned senorita who had been cast on the island by shipwreck. Though there can be no doubt of her noble and distinctive traits, any account which makes her out as anything but an Indian is purely fictitious.

The happy days she spent in Santa Barbara were to terminate even more abruptly than had her island exile. Just seven weeks after her arrival Father Sanchez of the Old Mission was called to the bedside of the dying woman. He gave her conditional baptism and the Christian name of Juana Maria. Her mortal remains were finally laid to rest in the Old Mission cemetery on the 19th of October, in the year 1853.

That is the story of Juana Maria, the lone woman of San Nicolas Island. This strange tale has come down to us in the written accounts of George Nidever and Carl Dittmann, and has been a popular tradition in California for nearly a hundred years.

When methodical historians came to write the history of California, they sought confirmation of the story in the official records of Santa Barbara's old Mission. When no document was found attesting the alledged baptism by Fr. Sanchez, an element of doubt began to enshroud the story. Fr. Zephyrin Engelhardt, O.F.M., the famed historian of the California Missions, spent a great deal of time looking for the missing entry. The fruitlessness of his search prompted him to write in his Santa Barbara Mission: "Were it not that Mr. Nidever's fame for veracity appears above suspicion, we should declare the whole story a myth, for the reason that, after a close examination of the Baptismal Registers at the Mission and at the Parish Church of Santa Barbara, we failed to discover any entry regarding the woman's Baptism in either the Mission or the Parish Church. Likewise, there is no record noted of her burial in the Mission Cemetery . . . a document or paper containing the story of the Lone Woman we cannot verify. We found no such account among the numerous papers in the Archives nor anywhere else."

In May of 1932 Fr. Zephyrin was approached again on this same subject by Dr. William Henry Ellison, a professor at the Santa Barbara State College, who was editing the personal memoirs of Captain George Nidever in a volume entitled, The Life and Adventures of George Nidever. Dr. Ellison writes: "In a conversation with Father Engelhardt in May, 1932, the editor asked the Mission historian if there were any further light on the question of the baptism and burial of the Indian woman. He said he knew of none but that he would reexamine the Mission records. In a letter from him to William Ellison, May 14, 1932, he says: 'The Baptismal Register from 1851 to 1858 has no Juana Maria entered by Fr. Sanchez or anyone else . . . I believe it will never be cleared up, as there is no document extant in our archives . . .'"

On the evening of January 19, 1944, two clerics of the Old Mission, Frater Blaise Cronin and Frater Kenneth Henriques, were doing some research on the Juana Maria incident for an article to appear in their student publication Priestly Studies. In the lower left hand corner opposite page 114 of the Burial Register of the Santa Barbara Presidio they found the following entry:

1183	En 19 de Octe de 1853 di sepulta ecca en este cemento al cadaver de Juana Maria india traída de la Isla de S. Nicolas, y como no habia qn. le entendiese su idioma fue bautizada sub condicione por el P. Sanchez; y pa qe conste lo firmo.
Juana Maria	Fr. J ^o Ma ^r de J ^s Gonz ^z
India adlta.	

(Juana Maria Indian woman. On the 19th of October of 1853 I gave ecclesiastical burial in this cemetery to the mortal remains of Juana Maria an Indian brought from the Island of San Nicolas, and since there was no one who understood her language she was baptized conditionally by Fr. Sanchez; and that this may stand as true I sign it. Father Jose Maria de Jesus Gonzalez).

The story of Juana Maria was presumably the basis of Victor Herbert's opera, Natoma. But it is a far cry from the real life story of Juana Maria. That the life of Juana Maria has the broad sweep of an epic can hardly be denied. In the hands of a capable writer it may easily become another "Ramona" -- a thrilling and remarkable page in the story of California in the Mission days.

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